

Word family: **conversation / conversations / conversational / conversationally / conversationalist / converse**

Base word: conversation

Plural: conversations

Related forms: conversational, conversationally, conversationalist, converse

Useful expressions / extensions: have a conversation, make conversation, conversation starter, conversation piece, join the conversation, national/public conversation

Part of speech: mainly noun (名詞) / adjective and verb family (相關形容詞及動詞)

Your sentence:

> “She is not the sort of person who tries to dominate a **conversation**...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **conversation** means **a spoken exchange in which two or more people talk to one another and respond to each other**.

In your passage, the point is that your grandmother does not try to control the discussion or take most of the speaking time.

繁體中文： **兩個或以上的人互相說話、回應和交流想法的談話 / 對話**

中文翻譯：

> “She is not the sort of person who tries to dominate a conversation...”

「她不是那種會試圖主導整個**對話 / 談話**的人.....」

Here:

conversation = 人與人之間有來有往、互相回應的口頭交流

1. **conversation = spoken exchange between people (談話 / 對話) — 對話 ; 交談**

This is the exact sense in your passage.

Practice 1 — Original

> “She is not the sort of person who tries to dominate a **conversation**.”

「她不是那種會試圖主導整個**對話**的人。」

Practice 2

> “We had a long **conversation** after dinner.”

「晚飯後，我們進行了一次很長的**談話**。」

Practice 3

> “Their **conversation** became more serious.”

「他們的**對話**變得更嚴肅了。」

conversation = 兩個或以上的人透過說話互相交流想法、資訊或感受

2. **have a conversation** — 進行對話；談一談

A very common construction.

Practice 4

> “I need to **have a conversation** with her.”

「我需要跟她**談一談**。」

Practice 5

> “They had a private **conversation** about the problem.”

「他們就這個問題進行了一次私下**談話**。」

have a conversation = 與某人進行一段有來有往的口頭交流

3. **conversation about + topic** (關於某事的談話) — 討論；交談

Practice 6

> “We had a **conversation about** family life.”

「我們談了一次**關於家庭生活的話題**。」

Practice 7

> “The **conversation about** work lasted an hour.”

「關於工作的**談話**持續了一小時。」

conversation about something = 以某個主題為中心的交談

4. **conversation with + person** (與某人交談) — 與.....的談話

Practice 8

> “I had a useful **conversation with** my teacher.”

「我跟老師進行了一次很有用的**談話**。」

Practice 9

> “Her **conversation with** the manager was brief.”

「她跟經理的**談話**很簡短。」

conversation with someone = 與某個特定人物進行的交談

5. **make conversation** (找話題聊天) — 找話題；寒暄

A useful fixed expression.

Practice 10

> “He tried to **make conversation** while they waited.”

「等候期間，他嘗試**找話題聊天**。」

Practice 11

> “She asked about the weather just to **make conversation**.”

「她問天氣，只是為了**找話題寒暄**。」

make conversation = 為避免冷場或保持社交互動而主動找話題交談

This is different from simply “have a conversation.”

6. **join the conversation — 加入談話**

Practice 12

> “She listened for a while before **joining the conversation**.”

「她先聽了一會兒，然後才**加入談話**。」

Practice 13

> “More people gradually **joined the conversation**.”

「更多人逐漸**加入討論**。」

join the conversation = 開始參與原本已在進行中的談話 / 討論

7. **start / begin a conversation — 開始談話；開啟話題**

Practice 14

> “He **started a conversation** with the person next to him.”

「他跟旁邊的人**開始交談**。」

Practice 15

> “That question **began a conversation** about family traditions.”

「那個問題**開啟了一場關於家庭傳統的討論**。」

start a conversation = 令一段交談開始

8. **conversation = broader public discussion (社會 / 公共討論) — 公共討論；整體話語**

This is the main figurative extension.

Practice 16

> “The issue has become part of the national **conversation**.”

「這個議題已成為全國**公共討論的一部分**。」

Practice 17

> “The film changed the public **conversation** about ageing.”

「這部電影改變了社會對老齡問題的**公共討論方式**。」

conversation = 社會、媒體或公眾圍繞某個議題持續進行的廣泛討論，而不是一次字面上的談話

This is a genuine figurative meaning.

9. **national/public conversation (公共議題中的持續討論) — 社會討論；公共話語**

Practice 18

> “Mental health is now part of the public **conversation**.”

「心理健康現在已成為**公共討論**的一部分。」

Practice 19

> “The article contributed to the national **conversation**.”

「這篇文章對全國性的**公共討論**作出了貢獻。」

public/national conversation = 大量人透過媒體、公開活動、網絡等共同參與的持續討論

10. **conversation = exchange between fields/ideas (領域之間的對話) — 交流；對話**

A figurative academic/design use.

Practice 20

> “The exhibition creates a **conversation** between art and technology.”

「這個展覽在藝術與科技之間建立了一種**對話 / 交流**。」

Practice 21

> “The book places tradition in **conversation with** modern ideas.”

「這本書讓傳統與現代思想形成**對話**。」

conversation = 兩種思想、學科、藝術形式或傳統之間互相呼應、影響或比較的關係

This is more abstract and academic than ordinary spoken conversation.

11. **conversation piece — 引人談論的物件 / 話題物**

A useful lexicalized expression.

Practice 22

> “The unusual lamp became a **conversation piece**.”

「那盞特別的燈成為一件很容易**引起話題的物件**。」

Practice 23

> “The painting is a real **conversation piece**.”

「這幅畫非常**引人談論 / 很能引起話題**。」

conversation piece = 因特別、有趣或引人注意而容易令人開始談論的物件

12. **conversation starter — 開場話題；引起交談的東西**

Practice 24

> “That question is a good **conversation starter**.”

「那個問題是一個很好的**開場話題**。」

Practice 25

> “The photo became an easy **conversation starter**.”

「那張照片很容易成為**開啟話題的東西**。」

conversation starter = 能幫助人開始交談的問題、物件或話題

13. **conversation skills — 交談技巧**

Practice 26

> “Good **conversation skills** are useful in interviews.”

「良好的**交談技巧**在面試中很有用。」

Practice 27

> “She has excellent **conversation skills**.”

「她有很好的**談話 / 溝通技巧**。」

conversation skills = 在交談中提問、聆聽、回應和維持互動的能力

14. **conversational = relating to informal conversation (交談式的) — 對話式的 ; 口語化的**

A major adjective form.

Practice 28

> “The article uses a **conversational** style.”

「這篇文章使用較**口語化、像交談一樣的風格**。」

Practice 29

> “Her presentation sounded natural and **conversational**.”

「她的簡報聽起來很自然，很有**交談感**。」

conversational = 像日常談話一樣自然、非正式、容易理解的

15. **conversational = able to communicate in a language (語言程度) — 能作日常交談的**

A very useful language-learning sense.

Practice 30

> “She is **conversational** in French.”

「她的法語已達到**可以進行日常交談的程度**。」

Practice 31

> “He has **conversational** Japanese.”

「他的日語程度足以作**一般日常交談**。」

conversational + language = 語言能力足以處理一般日常對話，但不一定達到流利 / 專業程度

16. **conversationally = in an informal spoken style (以口語 / 交談方式) — 口語化地；像聊天般地**

Practice 32

> “She explained the idea **conversationally**.”

「她以很**口語、像聊天般的方式**解釋這個概念。」

Practice 33

> “The guide was written **conversationally**.”

「這本指南以較**口語化的風格**寫成。」

conversationally = 以自然、非正式、近似日常談話的方式

17. **conversationalist = person skilled at conversation (善於交談的人) — 健談而懂得交談的人**

Practice 34

> “She is an excellent **conversationalist**.”

「她是一個非常**善於交談的人**。」

Practice 35

> “A good **conversationalist** knows how to listen.”

「一個善於交談的人懂得如何**聆聽別人**。」

****conversationalist = 善於維持有趣、平衡而自然談話的人****

This does not simply mean someone who talks a lot.

18. ****converse — verb = talk with someone (交談) — 交談 ; 談話****

A related formal verb.

Practice 36

> “They ****conversed**** quietly for an hour.”

「他們安靜地****交談**了一個小時******。」

Practice 37

> “She enjoys ****conversing**** with people from different backgrounds.”

「她喜歡跟不同背景的人****交談****。」

****converse = 與某人互相交談****

Register:

> more formal than ****talk****

In ordinary conversation:

> “We talked.”

is much more common than:

> “We conversed.”

Important distinction: ****conversation vs talk****

****conversation****

usually suggests:

> two-way interaction with people responding to each other.

talk

is broader and can mean:

- * conversation
- * speech
- * lecture
- * act of speaking

> “We had a conversation.”

= 我們進行了一段有來有往的談話。

> “She gave a talk.”

= 她作了一場演講。

So **conversation** more strongly implies interaction.

Important distinction: **conversation vs discussion**

conversation

can be casual and does not need a clear objective.

discussion

usually suggests:

> talking about a particular subject in some detail.

> “We had a conversation over coffee.”

may be general.

> “We had a discussion about the budget.”

is more topic-focused.

They overlap, but **discussion** is often more deliberate.

Important distinction: **conversation vs chat**

chat

is usually:

- * informal
- * light
- * relaxed

conversation

can be casual or serious.

> “We had a quick chat.”

= 我們隨便聊了一下。

> “We had a serious conversation.”

= 我們進行了一次嚴肅的談話。

So **conversation** is broader in tone.

Important distinction: **conversation vs dialogue**

conversation

is the ordinary everyday term for spoken interaction.

dialogue

can mean:

- * spoken exchange between people
- * scripted speech in drama
- * formal communication between groups

> “political dialogue”

= 政治對話

So **dialogue** can sound more formal or institutional.

Important distinction: **conversation vs speech**

conversation

= interactive, usually involving more than one person responding.

speech

can mean:

> one person speaking at length to an audience.

Your passage explicitly contrasts the grandmother's style with:

> “big speeches”

She prefers small actions and does not dominate conversations.

Important distinction: **conversation vs communication**

communication

is much broader.

It can include:

- * speech
- * writing
- * gestures
- * images
- * digital messages

conversation

normally refers to interactive exchange, especially spoken or conversation-like exchange.

So every conversation is communication, but not all communication is conversation.

Important distinction: **have a conversation vs make conversation**

This is crucial.

have a conversation

= actually talk with someone.

> “We had a conversation.”

make conversation

= deliberately find things to say, often for social politeness or to avoid silence.

> “He made conversation while they waited.”

So:

have conversation ≠ **make conversation**

Important distinction: **conversation — literal vs public conversation**

Literal:

> “They had a conversation.”

= 兩個 / 多人直接交談。

Figurative:

> “The issue entered the public conversation.”

= 這個議題成為社會廣泛討論的一部分。

There is no single literal conversation involving the whole public.

This is the main true figurative polysemy branch.

Important distinction: **conversational vs casual**

conversational

specifically means:

> resembling natural spoken interaction.

casual

means:

> informal / relaxed generally.

A shirt can be casual, but not conversational.

Writing can be both:

> casual and conversational.

Important distinction: **conversational language level vs fluent**

conversational

= able to manage ordinary everyday exchanges.

fluent

usually suggests a higher ability to communicate smoothly, flexibly, and with relatively little difficulty.

So:

> **conversational French**

does not necessarily mean:

> **fluent French**

Important distinction: **conversationalist vs talkative**

talkative

= talks a lot.

good conversationalist

= communicates well in conversation, which also involves:

- * listening
- * asking questions
- * responding
- * balancing turns

A person can be very talkative but a poor conversationalist.

This is especially relevant to your passage because your grandmother is ****not**** someone who dominates.

Important distinction: **converse** vs **converse******

A spelling note worth flagging.

**converse** — verb****

= talk

> “They conversed.”

**converse** — adjective/noun in logic/general language****

can also mean ****opposite/reversed relationship****, as in:

> “The converse is also true.”

= 反過來也成立。

This is actually a separate lexical branch of ****converse****, even though it belongs only loosely to the practical ****conversation**** family. Because your project values related modern forms, it is worth recognizing, but I would ****not fold that logical sense into the core conversation entry**** as though it were merely another meaning of “conversation.”

Family-extension note

Following the reference curation style, these are especially useful members and constructions of the ****conversation**** family:

- * ****conversation — spoken exchange**** = 對話 / 交談
- * ****have a conversation**** = 進行談話
- * ****conversation with/about**** = 與某人 / 關於某事的談話

* **make conversation** = 找話題聊天 / 寒暄
 * **join the conversation** = 加入談話
 * **start a conversation** = 開啟談話
 * **public/national conversation** = 社會公共討論
 * **conversation between fields/ideas** = 領域 / 思想之間的對話
 * **conversation piece** = 引人談論的物件
 * **conversation starter** = 開場話題
 * **conversation skills** = 交談技巧
 * **conversational — style** = 口語化 / 對話式的
 * **conversational — language ability** = 能進行日常交談的
 * **conversationally** = 以口語交談方式
 * **conversationalist** = 善於交談的人
 * **converse — verb** = 交談

This is exactly the kind of **moderate polysemy** case the scan manual allows: one strong everyday core sense, plus a genuine figurative public-discussion branch and several useful lexical/family extensions—without inventing lots of artificial meanings.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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conversation — spoken exchange	兩個或以上的人透過說話互相回應並交流想法、資訊或感受
have a conversation	與某人進行一段有來有往的口頭交流
conversation about something	以某個主題為中心進行的交談
conversation with someone	與某個特定人物進行的談話
make conversation	為避免冷場或保持社交互動而主動找話題聊天
join the conversation	開始參與一段已經在進行中的談話
start a conversation	令一段交談開始
public/national conversation	社會、公眾或媒體圍繞某議題持續進行的廣泛討論
conversation between fields/ideas	不同思想、學科或藝術形式之間的互相呼應、交流或比較
conversation piece	因特別或有趣而容易引起別人談論的物件
conversation starter	能幫助人開始交談的問題、物件或話題
conversation skills	在談話中提問、聆聽、回應並維持互動的能力
conversational — style	像自然日常談話一樣非正式、流暢而易理解的
conversational — language ability	語言能力足以應付一般日常交談的
conversationally	以自然、非正式、接近日常交談的方式
conversationalist	善於聆聽、回應並維持自然有趣談話的人
converse — verb	與某人互相交談；較正式用語

For your original sentence

> “She is not the sort of person who tries to dominate a **conversation**, but when she does speak, people listen.”

The exact meaning is:

conversation = 兩個或以上的人有來有往地說話、互相回應和交流的談話

Therefore:

> **dominate a conversation**

= **「主導整場談話，佔據過多發言空間或控制話題方向」**

The contrast in your passage is important:

> she does not **dominate conversation**

but:

> people listen when she does speak.

So **conversation** here is ordinary interpersonal dialogue, while the broader polysemy worth learning later is:

> **public conversation**

> = 社會廣泛討論

and:

> **conversation between ideas/fields**

> = 不同思想或領域之間的抽象「對話」.